

NETWORKSHEET

UNDERSTANDING YOUR NETWORK

From getting hired to getting things done and getting ahead, hardly anyone disputes the importance of “who you know” in business. Yet, a growing body of research has shown that not all networks are created equal. A good network can accelerate your career, but many of us end up building networks that are ineffective at best, counterproductive at worst, holding you back.

This worksheet is designed to help you think more carefully about what your network looks like and how it might be affecting you and your career.

You will be asked to name people from your core professional network, think about your relationships with them, and draw your network.

Step 1. Who’s in your network?

Think of people you have relied on or benefitted from the most in the last 2-3 years. For each type of support below, write their initials. They may be people you see every day or much less often, as long as they have played an important role in your professional life. You may list the same names more than once.

- A. Technical expertise:** Name up to 4 people you go to for technical or operational advice and solutions. These people help you solve problems and get things done efficiently or creatively because of their expertise.

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- B. Insider information:** Name up to 4 people you go to for information about new opportunities, events, or happenings at work or in your profession.

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- C. Political support:** Name up to 4 people you rely on to help you secure resources, positions, or opportunities to do new things or meet new people because of their role or influence.

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- D. Guidance:** Name up to 4 people you go to for wisdom and feedback to help you grow professionally and personally. You consider them mentors to you.

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- E. Inspiration:** Name up to 4 people you go to for inspiration (energy, focus, ideas) at work. They inspire, challenge, or encourage you to strive toward important goals.

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- F. Friendship:** Name up to 4 people who have been the most important peers. You can discuss personal or non-professional matters with them. They make you feel accepted.

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Step 2. How well do you know your contacts?

Now that you've identified some of the key contacts in your network, let's think about the quality and strength of those relationships. Please answer the questions below for each contact in your network.

This section may feel rather tedious depending on how many contacts you have identified, but please do not rush. It is an important part of understanding how you manage your relationships.

How close do you feel towards your contacts? On a 4-point scale (4=very close, 3=rather close, 2=somewhat close, 1=rather distant), write down any contact you currently consider only somewhat close or rather distant.

How often do you talk to them during normal work hours? Write down any contact you have not talked to in 6 months or more.

How often do you talk to them outside of work hours? Write down any contact you have not seen outside of work hours in 6 months or more.

How balanced are your relationships? Are you in their network as much as they are in yours? Do they come to you for support, advice, or company as much as you go to them? Or do you feel that your relationships are one-sided? Write down everyone from your contacts if you feel that you have an unbalanced or one-sided (in either direction) relationship.

What do you know about them? Do you know their hobbies and passions? Their last vacation? Such questions may not seem relevant, but it is helpful to think about how much you have invested in getting to know each person. Write their initials next to each item below if you do not know anything about them on each topic.

- Family (e.g., Do they have siblings or children? Where do their parents live?)

- Friends (e.g., Do you know anything about their best friends?)

- Education (e.g., What is their highest degree? Where did they get their education?)

- Hobbies and interests (e.g., How do they spend their free time?)

- Favorite food (e.g., What do they enjoy eating? Do they have favorite restaurants?)

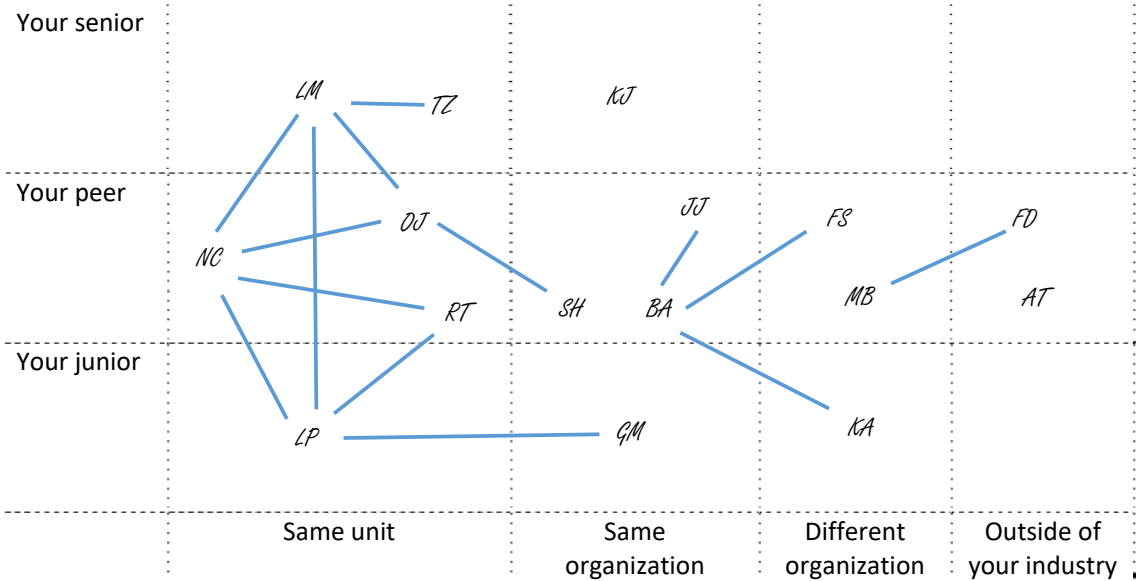
- Cultural background (e.g., Where and how did they grow up?)

Step 3. What does your network look like?

Draw your network of contacts from Step 1 below, based on whether each person is 1) your senior, peer, or junior in status and 2) works in the same unit or function, different unit but same organization, different organization, or outside of your industry.

Next, draw a line connecting your contacts if they are good friends or colleagues (they spend time together on their own without you). If you are not sure, assume they are not connected.

Example



Your network

